

# Parts / Developmental Fragmentation

with Mariah Rooney and Kai Cheng Thom

# AGENDA

The Dissociative Spectrum  
Development + Function of Parts  
Psychoeducation  
Demonstration  
Q & A  
Breakout Sessions



# THE DISSOCIATIVE SPECTRUM

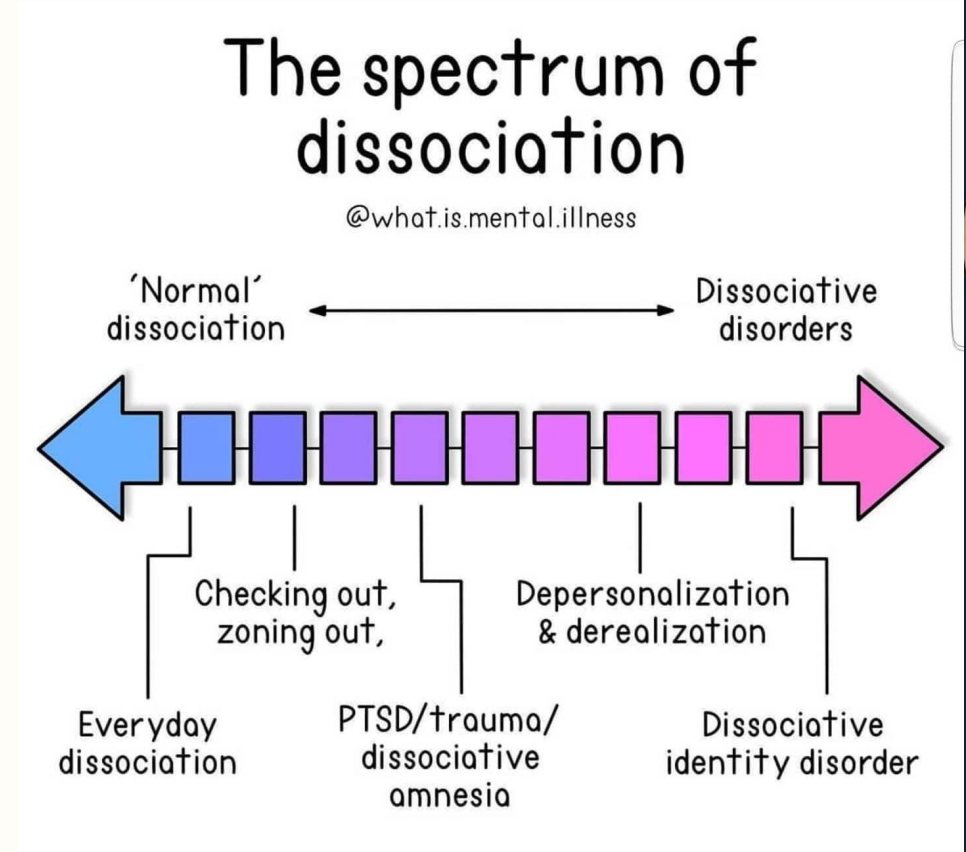
# DISSOCIATION

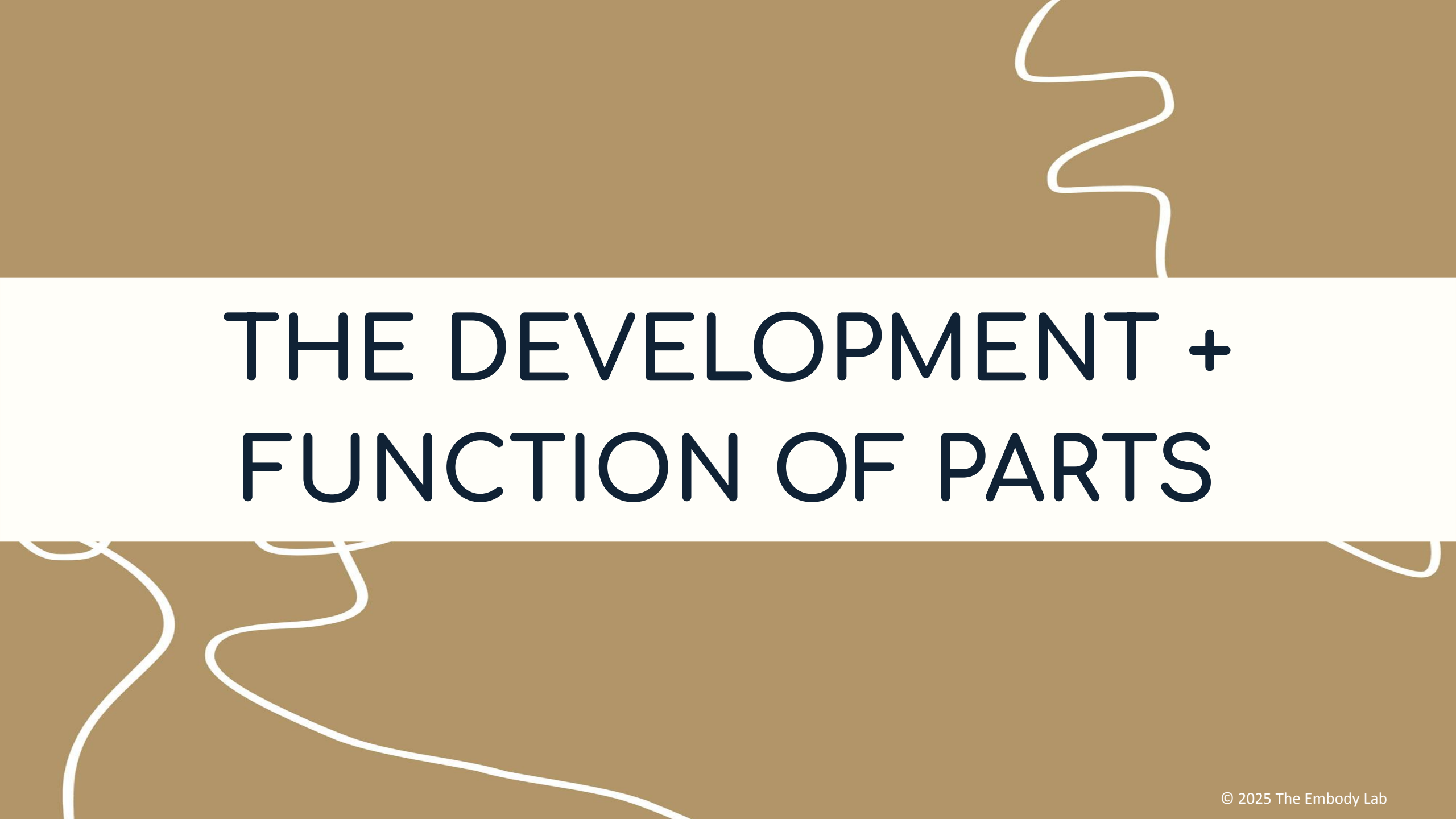
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- Dissociation is a coping strategy utilized to deal with overwhelming trauma and neglect
- A disturbance or alteration in the normally integrative functions of:
  - Identity
  - Memory
  - Somatic
  - Consciousness
- Thus traumatic experience is not:
  - Not fully stored in autobiographical memory
  - Not (often/fully) available to the conscious mind
- Needs to be understood as an attempt to preserve the self
- It is important to respect and understand the protective nature of dissociative defenses
- Learn about the unique patterns of dissociation with each client.
- It may be preventing client from feeling their full range of affect and disrupting functioning

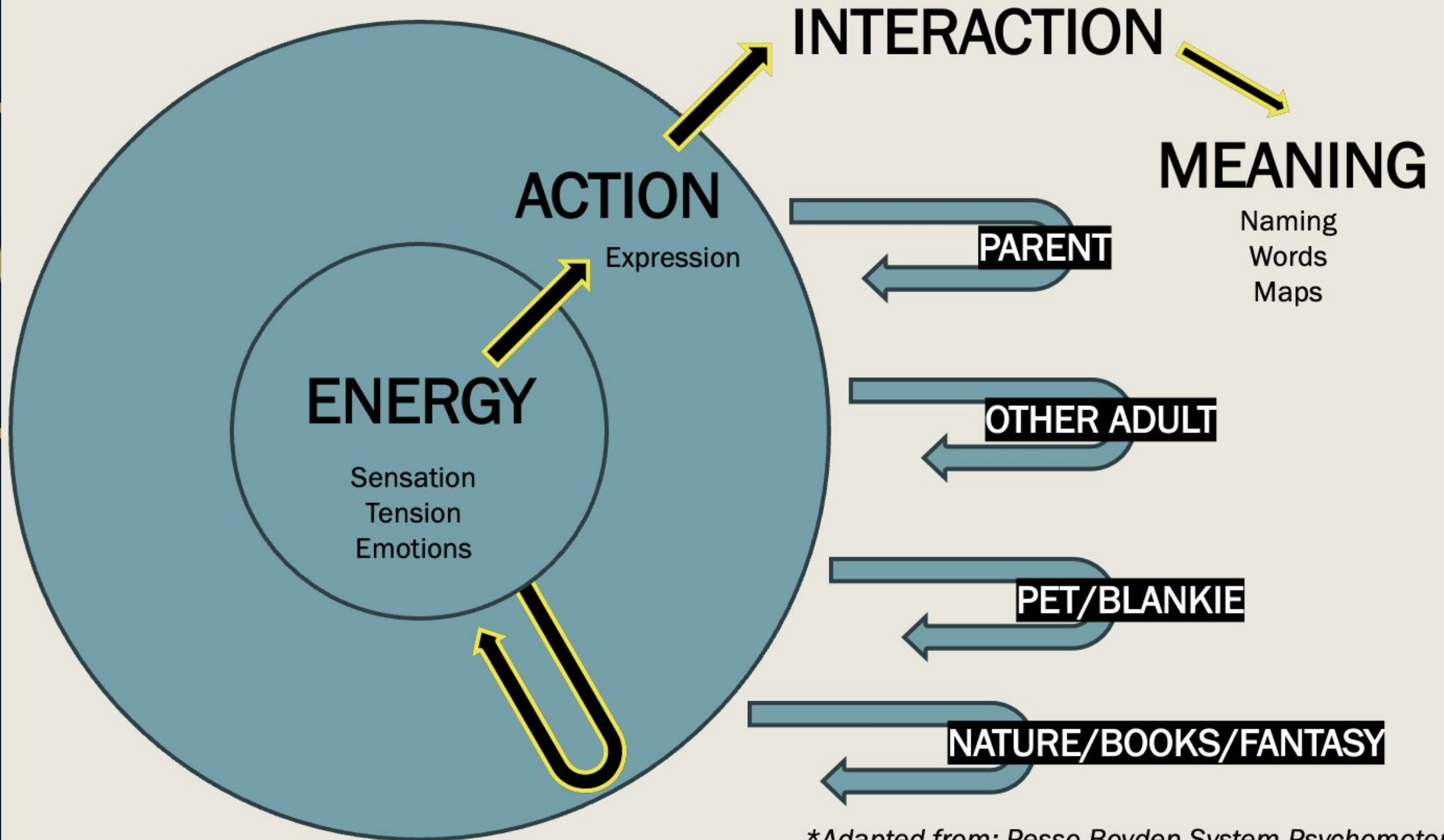
# THE SPECTRUM OF DISSOCIATION

- Daydreaming/Zoning out
- Sleepwalking
- Stupor
- Derealization
- Depersonalization (like watching a movie)
- Numbing, emotional detachment
- Somatization
- Amnesia
- A lack of a sense of self-identity
- Dissociative Identity Disorder



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# THE DEVELOPMENT + FUNCTION OF PARTS



*\*Adapted from: Pesso Boyden System Psychomotor*

# THE DEVELOPMENT OF PARTS

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Parts of Self develop, are shaped by and continue to exist as a result of influences within family and culture(s) of origin, historical context, as well as current sociopolitical context

Parts that hold  
adaptive,  
protective roles

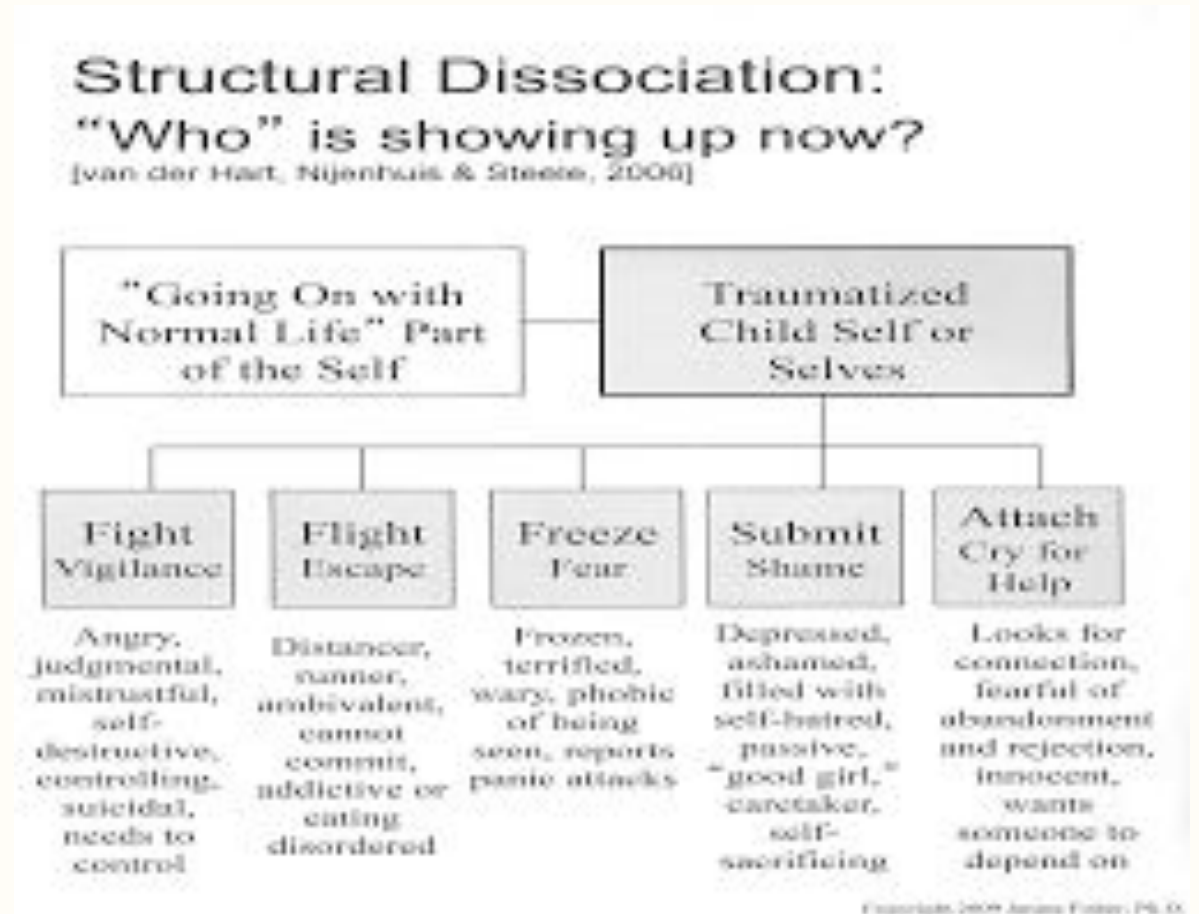
Child/Young Parts

Dissociated/  
Dissociative/  
Trauma Parts

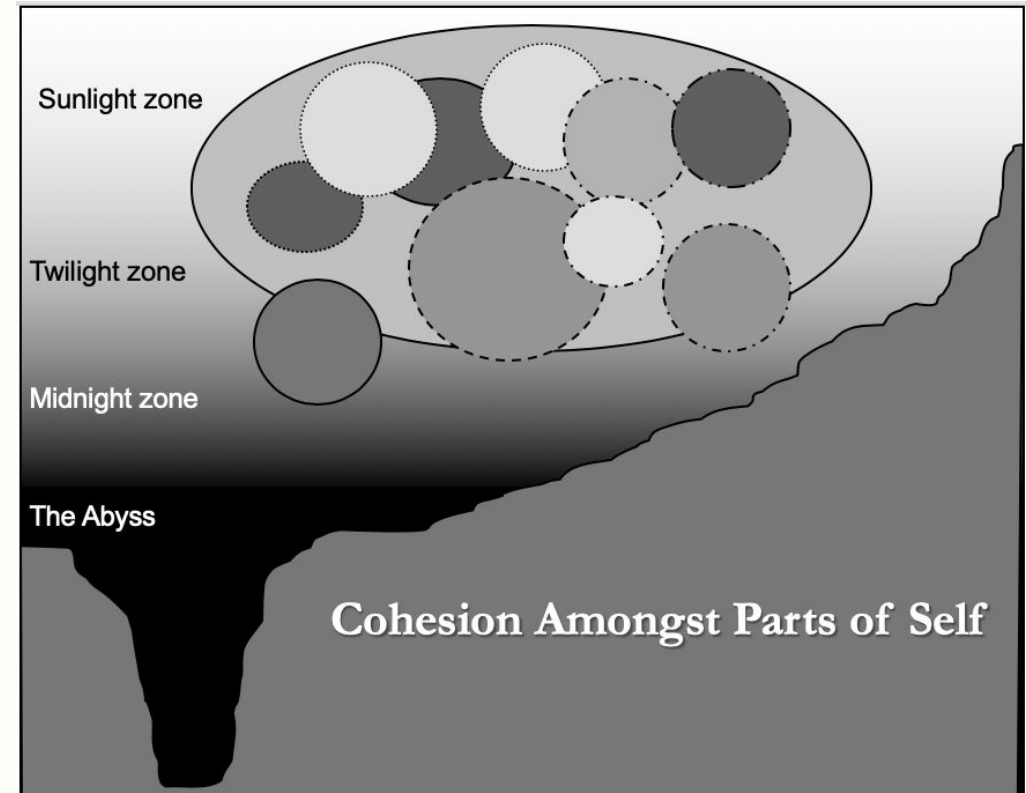
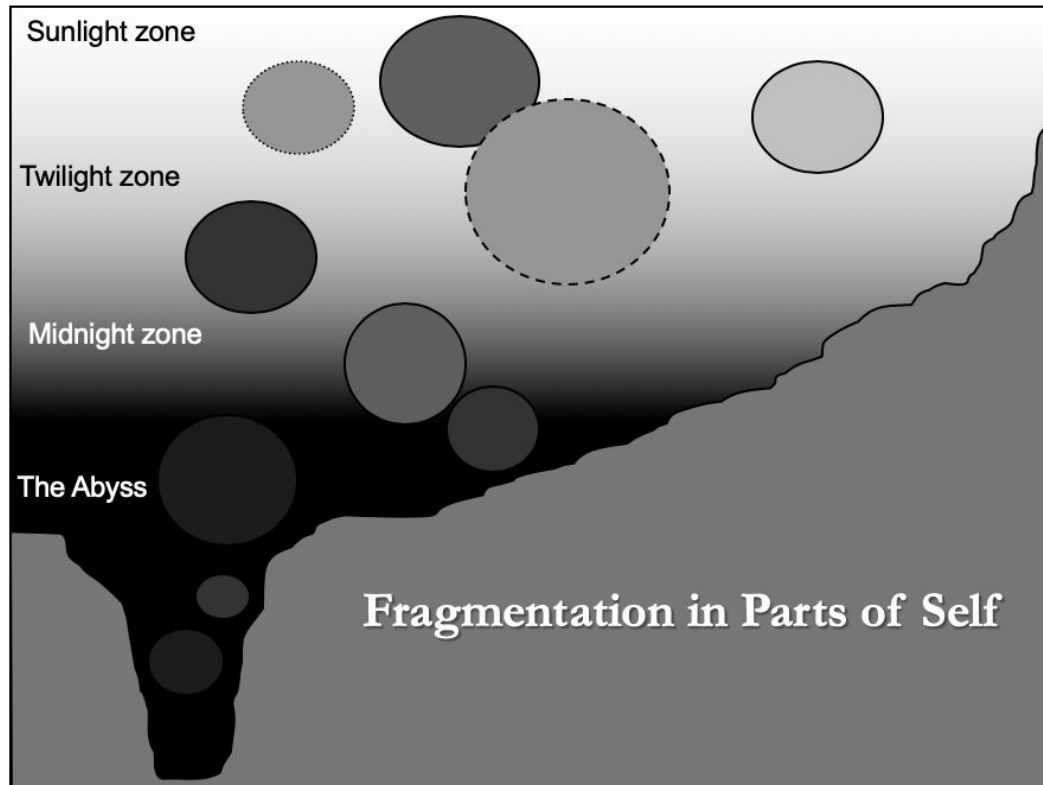


# THE DEVELOPMENT OF PARTS

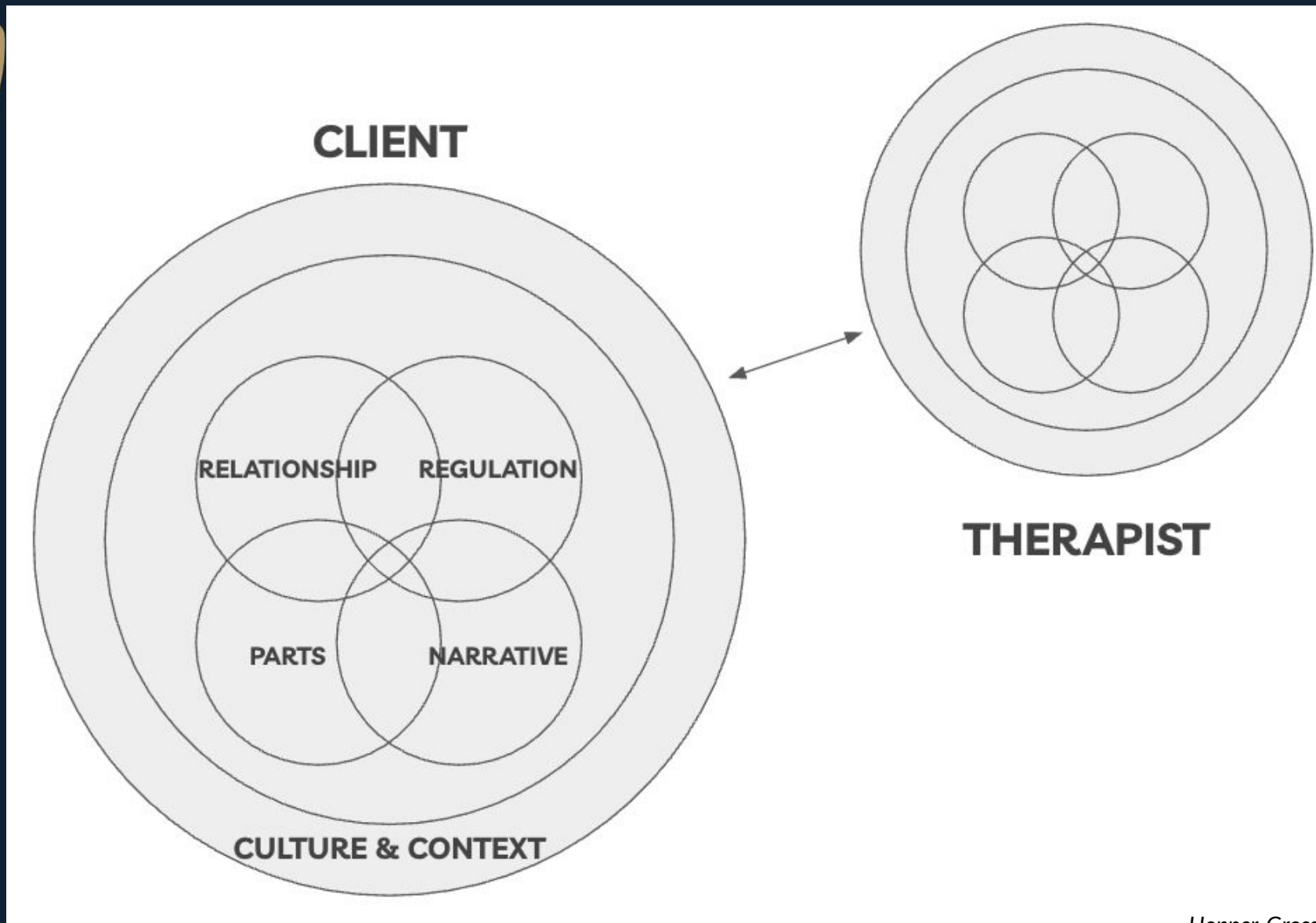
- One powerful somatic way to work with parts and dissociation is to link nervous system states (Porges' polyvagal theory) and structural dissociation (van der Hart, Nijenhuis & Steele); this is an innovation largely credited to Janina Fisher
- What “parts” of the personality tend to be connected with specific nervous system survival strategies?



# FROM FRAGMENTATION TO COHESION



Hopper, Grossman, Spinazzola & Zucker



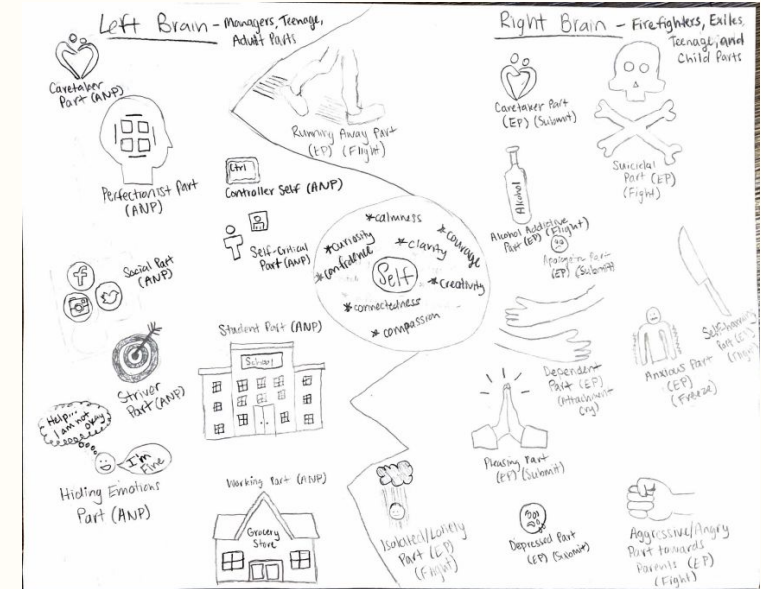
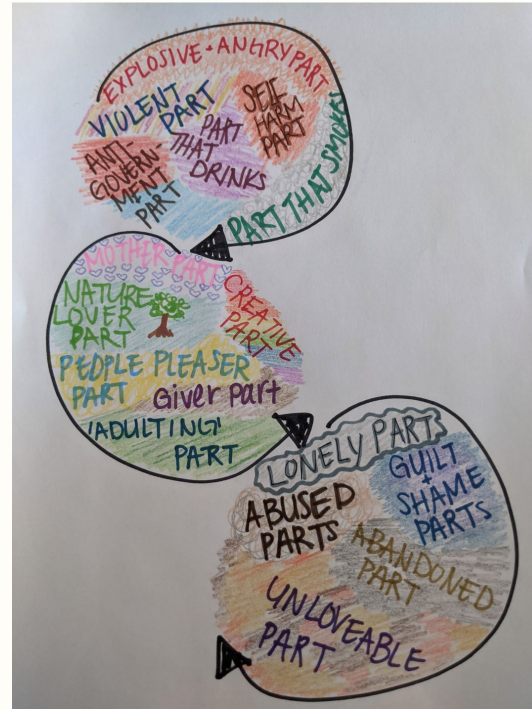
*Hopper, Grossman, Spinazzola & Zucker*



# PSYCHOEDUCATION FOR CLIENTS

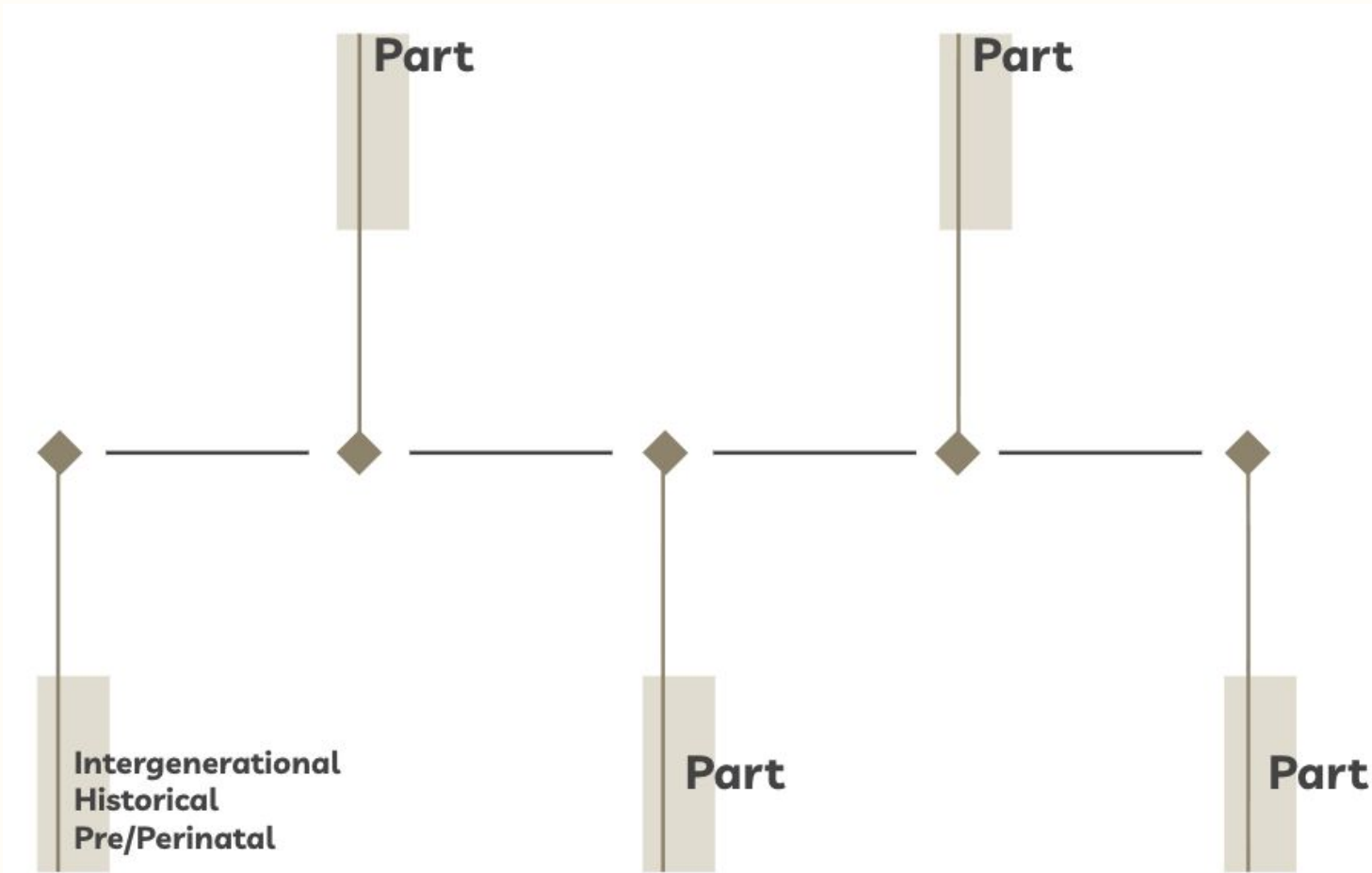


# MAPPING PARTS



# PARTS TIMELINE

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# SOMATIC PATTERNS OF PARTS

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- Many parts work models are largely cognitive/conceptual (thinking, naming, narrativizing) or imaginal (externalizing, symbolizing, visioning/dreaming in the tradition of Jungian psychology) - somatics-based approaches invites us to observe and make contact with the deeply embodied experience of parts, ie Hakomi, Focusing, Strozzi/Generative Somatics, Sensorimotor Psychotherapy
- Somatic concepts related or similar to “parts”
  - Somatic “shape” - the way a body organizes itself in response to experience; a constellation of postures, micro-movements, sensations, moods, and narratives animated by a specific drive
  - Conditioned tendency - reflexive psychobiological patterns that emerge in response to pressure, ie towards/away from/against (Strozzi)
  - Survival strategy - nervous system patterns that react to threat (neuroception)

# Foundations of Somatic Parts Work

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- You know the theory of parts, but how do we start to work with them in session? Particularly when the client may not be aware of “parts” theory?
- Somatic cuing & questioning - helping a client become aware of and notice parts through sensation and feeling
  - Guide the client to notice posture and micro-movement
  - Invite awareness of sensations within the body and amplify with reflections (repeat back or paraphrase what the client is saying)
  - Offer the language of parts without “leading” or directing - ask questions - is there a mood or emotion to the sensation? An image? A reflex? What is it trying to move towards, or away from? To take care of? What does it want for you? Etc
- Assume - all parts are in their way attempting to move towards life; apply unconditional positive regard (Rogers) *to each part*, be curious about the strategy of the part





# DEMONSTRATION

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# QUESTIONS



# BREAKOUT SESSIONS

# Discussion Prompts

1. Where in your practice do you notice somatic “shapes,” conditioned tendencies, or survival strategies emerging as parts of self?

*What cues...posture, micromovements, tone, reflexes...signal that a part is present or activated?*

2. How might you introduce parts work to a client who has never encountered the concept, without being directive or overly cognitive?

3. What somatic cueing or questions from today feel most accessible for you to bring into your next session?